

# Toward An Evolutionary Informed Understanding of Cross-Sex Friendships: A Theoretical Gap in Prior Research

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# Can men and women be just friends?

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Definitely not

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It depends

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Definitely yes

# When Harry Met Sally (1989)



# Evolved Psychology of Opposite-Sex Friendships: A Brief History

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- Bleske & Buss (2000)
- Bleske-Rechek & Buss (2001)
- Koenig et al. (2007)
- Lewis et al. (2011)
- Lewis et al. (2012)
- Bleske-Rechek et al. (2012)
- Bleske-Rechek et al. (2016)
- Szymkow & Frankowska (2022)



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All mentioned studies use evolutionary theory (primarily) to make predictions about the mating relevance of opposite-sex friends

Predictions derived from evolutionary theory provide a nuanced understanding of sex differences in opposite-sex friendships that are not easily explained by general social theories

Men, more than women, want to date their opposite-sex friends

(Bleske-Rechek et al., 2012)

Men, more than women, prioritize physical attractiveness in opposite-sex friends

(Lewis et al., 2011; Lewis et al., 2012)

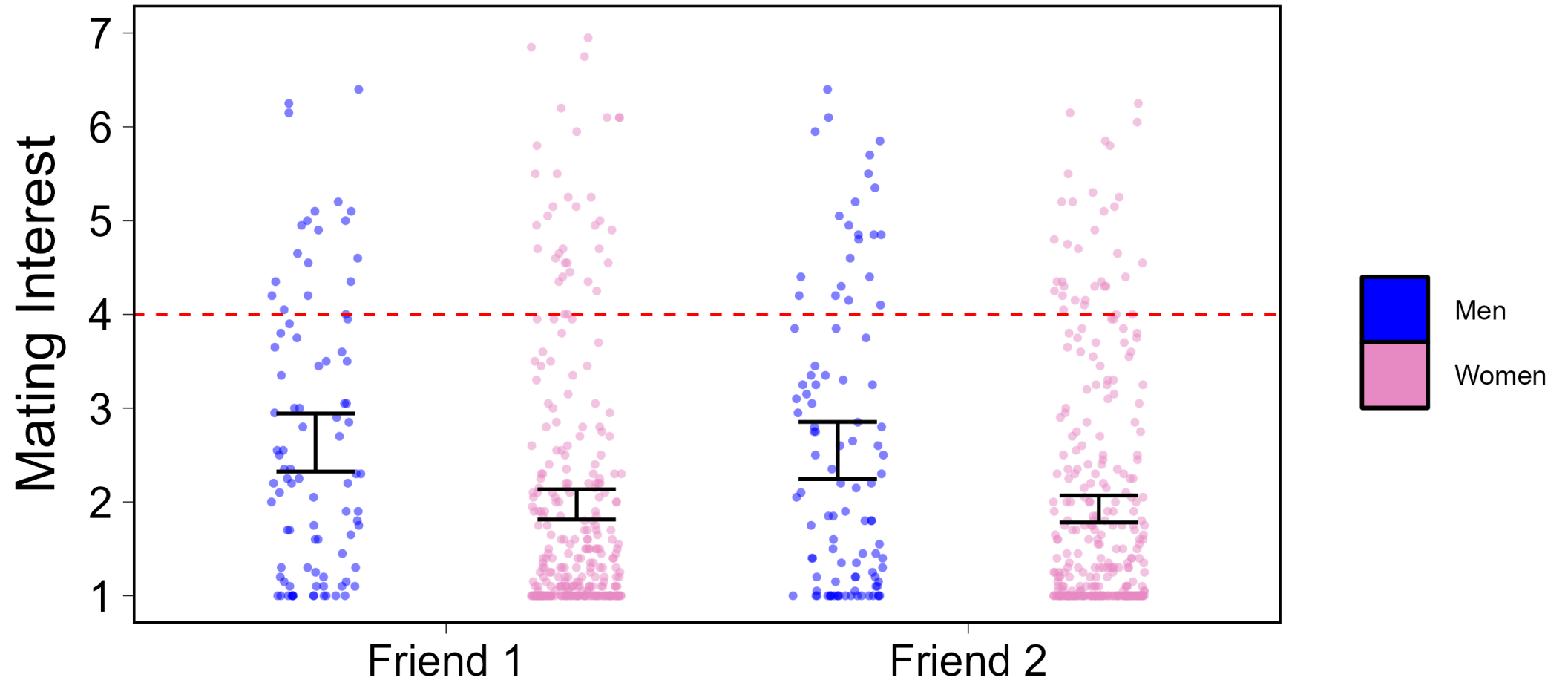
For women, more than men, a function of opposite-sex friends is physical protection

(Bleske & Buss, 2000)

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The same studies also find that opposite-sex friendships are strongly influenced by platonic motivations

# Most People are Not Romantically or Sexually Interested in Their Opposite-Sex Friends



Opposite-Sex  
Friends Can  
Serve Many  
Platonic  
Functions



# General Social Science Model

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- Opposite-sex friendships can serve a variety of proximate functions, such as emotional support, shared activities, social belonging, or even collaboration.
- There is nothing weird to explain about why men and women form opposite-sex friendships.



Did platonic  
opposite-sex  
friendships help  
our ancestors solve  
recurrent adaptive  
problems?



# Percent of species that have year-round male-female associations (van Schaik & Kappeler, 1997)

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Perissodactyla (mammals with hooves) **12.5%** ( $n = 8$ )

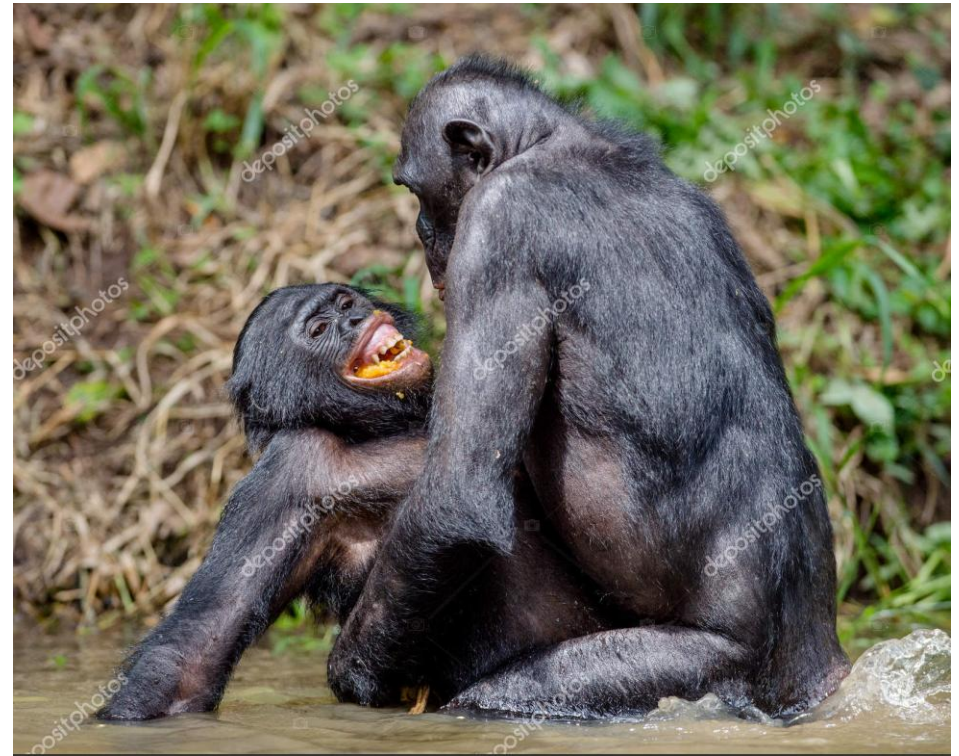
- Marsupialia (pouch mammals) **31.5%** ( $n = 54$ )
- Artiodactyla (placental mammals) **29.4%** ( $n = 68$ )
- Carnivora (meat-eating mammals) **31.0%** ( $n = 66$ )
- Chiroptera (bats) **31.0%** ( $n = 29$ )
- Primates **73.2%** ( $n = 56$ )

Most species don't even associate with the opposite-sex for pair bonding or spend time in social groups with opposite sex conspecifics

# What's happening with primates?

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Primates tend to live in multi-male, multi-female social groups and have promiscuous mating systems, where the functional benefits of opposite-sex bonds are limited to reproductive effort (Sterck et al., 2024).



# What about our closest relative, chimpanzees?

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- Chimpanzees provide rich comparative dataset to identify unique human adaptations (Muller, 2017)
- Promiscuous mating system (i.e., no platonic bonds) (Wrangham, 2002)
- Males and females form bonds, but the bonds are associated with reproductive effort (Langergraber et al., 2013; Machanda et al., 2013)



# What does this suggest?

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Given sexual reproduction, it is...

- 1) unsurprising that opposite-sex interactions across genera are largely restricted to reproductive effort
- 2) unsurprising that human opposite-sex friendships often include mating motivations
- 3) surprising that humans form genuinely platonic opposite-sex friendships

Thus, the interesting thing to explain is what psychological mechanisms evolved that allow humans to form platonic opposite-sex friendships

# Future Directions

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Platonic aspects of opposite-sex friendships need to be explained...

- Pair bonding
- Same-sex bonds
- Disgust

Underused method to explore aspects of mating psychology...

- Relationship initiation
- Backup mates and relationship dissolution
- Mate retention

Special thanks to the long list of people who have influenced my thinking on this topic.

April Bleske-Rechek, Geoffrey Miller, David Lewis, Steve Gangestad, William Costello, and Martin Muller

